



# Tips & Tricks



## Console-based calculator

To build a terminal-based calculator, add the following function to your `~/.bashrc` file:

```
function calc
{
    echo "${1}"|bc -l;
}
```

Reload Bash profile using the following command:

```
$source ~/.bashrc
```

Now run `calc` from terminal as:

```
$ calc 4+7*9-10/5
```

You will get the following output:

```
65.000000000000000000000000
```

Easy enough?

—*Parijat Chauhan, parijat.chauhan@aol.in*



## When did I execute a command?

Here is a tip that will help you understand when you did what. `history` will give the list of commands which you have executed earlier. If you want information on when you executed these commands, you need to do the following.

Open the `/etc/bashrc` file in a text editor and add the following:

```
export HISTTIMEFORMAT="%h/%d - %H:%M:%S "
```

After adding this line, re-login and execute the history command again. Now you will see the commands along with their time of execution. Here is an example:

```
<----output truncated---->
998 Apr/24 - 15:01:02 cd -
999 Apr/24 - 15:01:48 vi /etc/bashrc
1000 Apr/24 - 15:02:15 history
1001 Apr/24 - 15:03:06 ls
1002 Apr/24 - 15:03:12 ifconfig
1003 Apr/24 - 15:03:15 ls
1004 Apr/24 - 15:03:19 history
1005 Apr/24 - 15:03:49 vi /etc/bashrc
1006 Apr/24 - 15:03:52 history
1007 Apr/24 - 15:04:35 cd home
1008 Apr/24 - 15:04:37 ls
1009 Apr/24 - 15:04:50 vi httpd.conf
1010 Apr/24 - 15:07:37 vi httpd.conf
1011 Apr/24 - 15:07:48 history
<----output truncated---->
```

—*N Mohana Sundaram, mohan.linux@yahoo.com*



## Encrypt your file with Vim

Did you know Vim can help you encrypt your file so that no one can open it without knowing the encryption key? Well, all you need to do is to create a file with the `-x` flag:

```
vim -x filename
```

The above command will prompt you for an encryption key. Provide the key and remember it, as you will need it to open the file from now on.

—*Yakub Pasha, linux\_kernel@yahoo.com*



## Using Vi's `.exrc` file

As you know the `~/.exrc` file is used for making permanent settings to your Vi editor. If you place the following commands in this file, these commands will be available to all your subsequent Vi sessions: